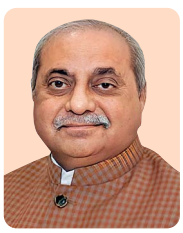
GLASSHOUSE

SECURITY DETAIL

On March 2, four days after the Rajya Sabha election for 10 seats in Uttar Pradesh, the BJP-led Union government provided Y-plus category security to **Akash Anand**, nephew of Bahujan Samaj Party chief Mayawati and officially the No. 2 in the party structure. The timing is significant as BJP's eighth candidate, Sanjay Seth, could manage an impossible victory because Umashankar Singh, the only BSP MLA in Uttar Pradesh, had voted in his favour. While political observers are seeing this as the BJP government's return gift to the BSP, the move has also antagonised many. Akash may not have asked for such security, but several Opposition leaders, including the controversial former Samajwadi Party MLC Swami Prasad Maurya, did seek one, unsuccessfully. Rumour mills are buzzing, suggesting an unofficial deal between the BJP and the BSP for the upcoming Lok Sabha polls.



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE



Pre-emptive Retirement?

Of the 15 candidates announced for Gujarat in the BJP's first list for the Lok Sabha polls, a third are new faces replacing the incumbents. But the biggest headline did not come from those who lost out or those who got tickets. It was the former deputy CM **Nitin Patel** announcing the withdrawal of his candidature from the Mehsana seat, where the saffron party has not named any candidate yet. It was a moment of déjà vu for Gujarat as Patel had similarly announced his 'refusal' to contest the Gujarat assembly polls in November 2022 to make way for fresh faces. Speculation is now rife about his political future.

Copy That

When he was a minister in the Uddhav Thackeray-led Shiv Sena government, **Eknath Shinde** reportedly did splendid work through the party's medical aid cell. In fact, this work is said to have stood him in good stead when he later made a bid for the Maharashtra chief minister's chair. Now, his deputy CM and BJP leader **Devendra Fadnavis** has launched a medical aid cell in his office to ensure that needy patients are accommodated in beds meant for them in charitable hospitals. Same pinch?





No Candidates for BRS

There seems no end to Bharat Rashtra Samithi supremo **K. Chandrashekar Rao**'s woes. First, his plans of going pan-India for the parliamentary polls came a cropper, followed by the debacle in the assembly polls, and now he is struggling to find candidates for nine of the 17 Lok Sabha seats his party had won in Telangana in 2019. Two of his MPs are running on a BJP ticket; more defections are to follow. Putting up a brave face, KCR says he will field debutants, even as the election is emerging as a Congress-BJP battle.

Toddy Cat Trouble

Though Kerala governor **Arif Mohammed Khan**, chief minister **Pinarayi Vijayan** and leader of the Opposition **V.D. Satheeshan** cannot see eye to eye, the three do have a common adversary—palm civets that invade their homes frequently. While attending an event at Akkulam, a city suburb, on February 29, CM Pinarayi revealed that palm civets, also called toddy cats, were giving him a lot of trouble and he could not drink a glass of water unless it was kept covered. Next day, Satheeshan too said he was facing palm civet menace at his official residence. In September 2022, Khan shifted residence to a five-star hotel after palm civets invaded his sleep. The Kerala public works department has now sanctioned Rs 6.67 crore for the immediate renovation of the bungalows to save the Kerala cabinet from palm civets.



Kaushik Deka with Ashish Misra, Jeemon Jacob, Jumana Shah, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, and Amarnath K. Menon